

A HOUR

As we arrived at The Ritz-Carlton, Bangalore, one early summer evening, we were led towards a designated corner, which shied away from the main property, where a hooded figure handed us a metal access card and ushered us into a dimly-lit elevator. We walked past a bustling kitchen, wondering if we had taken a wrong turn, until a discreet door opened to reveal The Cloak Society, a mysterious speakeasy with soft lighting where cloaked hosts glided between tables serving inventive cocktails and thoughtfully-paired small plates.



"Death Eaters!" my 10-year-old daughter, an unabashed Harry Potter fan, would have called them. It wasn't the hidden entrance that stayed with me, though. It was the thought and creativity that had gone into every little detail after we stepped inside. And that's perhaps where India's speakeasy culture is headed.

Always associated with hidden doors and whispered passwords, India's new wave of speakeasies is no longer defined by secrecy alone. From Delhi and Hyderabad to Goa and Bengaluru, bars are keeping pace with their international counterparts, creating immersive experiences where every detail, from the arrival and ambience to the cocktails, food and service, is carefully considered.

More than mystery

The original speakeasies flourished during America's Prohibition era, when secrecy was essential. Almost a century down the line, that very secrecy has become theatre. The hidden entrance sparks curiosity but what truly keeps guests coming back is everything that follows.

Few bars understand this evolution better than Pass Code Only (PCO) in New Delhi, widely regarded as India's first modern speakeasy. Thirteen years after it first opened its discreet doors, PCO still doesn't have a signboard. Yet cocktail aficionados know exactly where to find it, returning for its martinis, negronis and a bar experience that has transcended fads.

"Our biggest influence has been showing that a speakeasy isn't just a hidden door but an identity. Trends come